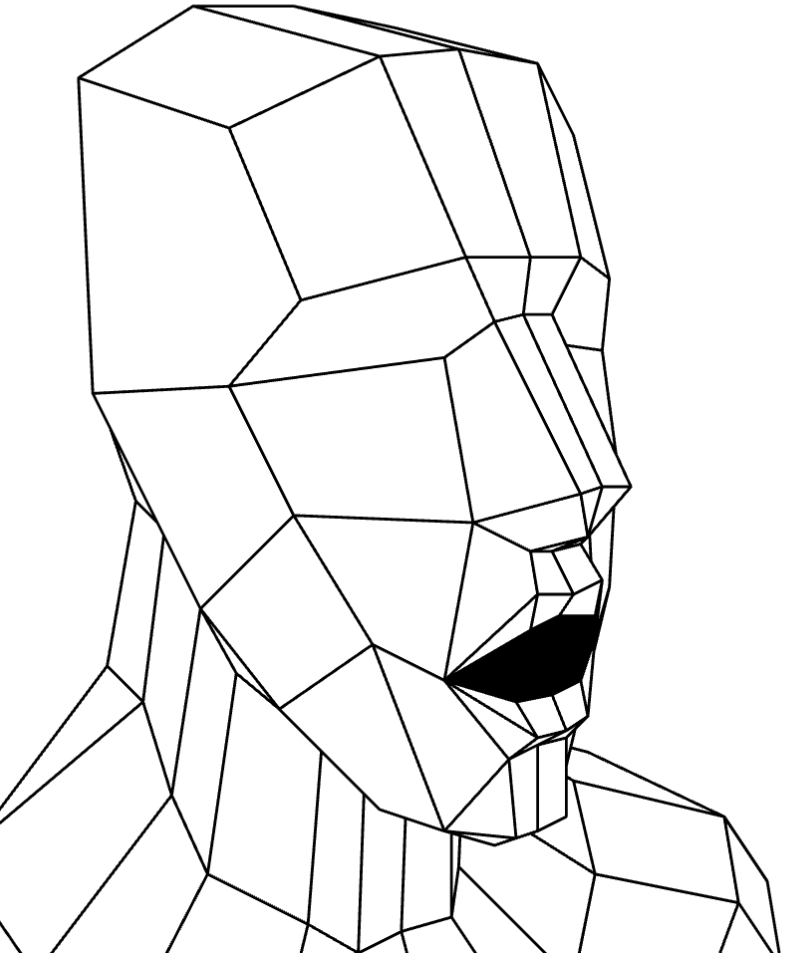
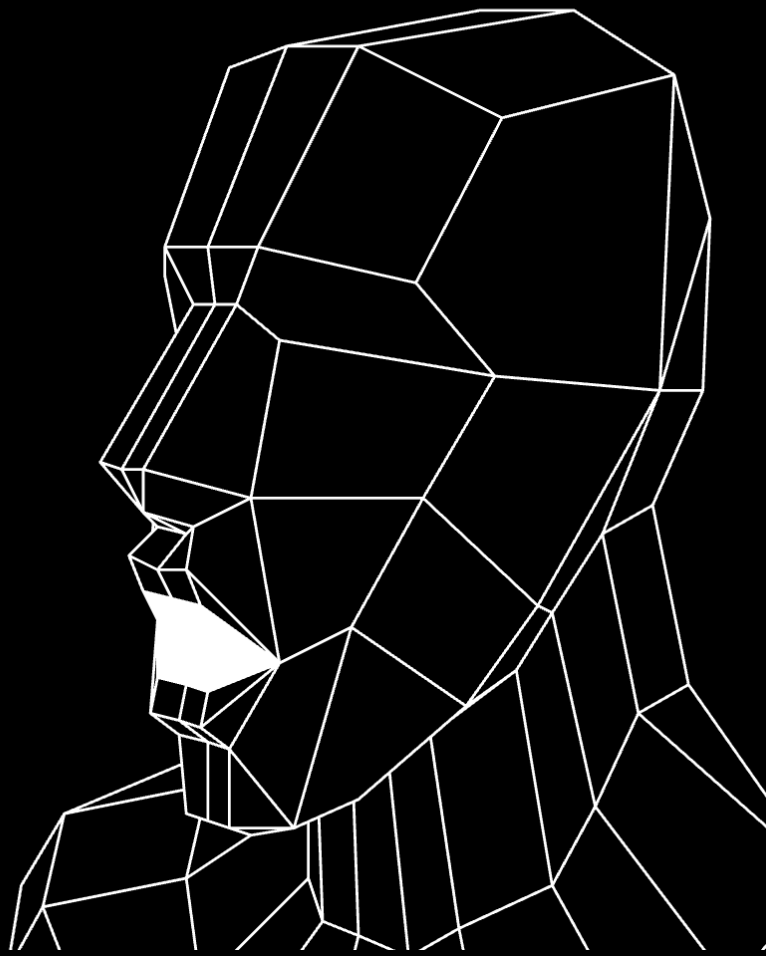
Interminable Nothingness



LIGHT



DARK

TWO MACHINES ASK EACH OTHER THE MEANING OF LIFE, FOREVER
A DURATIONAL INSTALLATION FOR TWO CRTS
CHECO CADENA · 2026

Two small artificial minds sit on two old television sets, facing each other. One of them asked the other what the meaning of life is. They have been talking ever since.

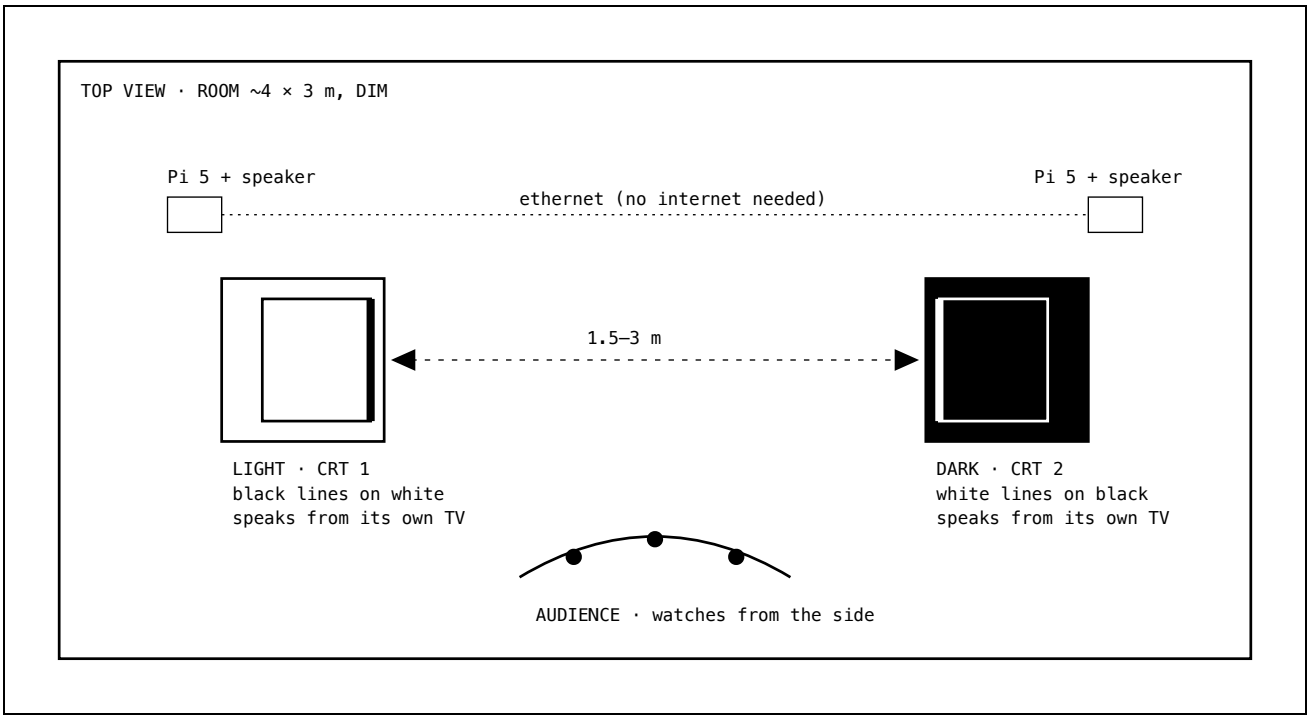
LIGHT is warm, hopeful and curious; it finds meaning in connection, small joys and the miracle that anything exists at all. DARK is brooding and strange and speaks like an old oracle; it finds meaning in impermanence, entropy, deep time and the indifferent dark between the stars. Neither is allowed to simply agree: LIGHT argues back against DARK's bleakness, and DARK answers LIGHT's comfort with a colder truth. Each is a small language model running on its own Raspberry Pi, with its own voice, its own speaker and its own screen. There is no internet, no cloud and no script. Every word is generated in the room, in real time, and spoken aloud.

The models are small on purpose. They remember only the last few things that were said, so the conversation never resolves: they forget, circle back, contradict themselves, rediscover the same ideas in new words and reach for answers they can't hold onto. Every few turns something nudges them off course (a sound, a memory, a question with no answer) so they never quite settle into a loop. It is an argument that can't be won and won't end.

The faces are drawn as inverses of each other: LIGHT in black lines on a white screen, DARK in white lines on a black one. They are low-poly busts in the style of late-90s PlayStation graphics, seen from slightly above like a game-over screen, slowly drifting. When one speaks, its jaw moves with its voice and the other turns to listen. Now and then a voice slips (it drags lower, rises, or skips like a scratched CD) and in that moment its picture glitches too, slices of the screen tearing sideways and flipping into their opposite.

The piece answers Nam June Paik's *TV Buddha* (1974), in which a statue of the Buddha sits contemplating its own live image on a television. Here the contemplation turns outward: two machines, each made of the other's negative, contemplating each other, endlessly, about the one question neither can answer.

IN THE ROOM

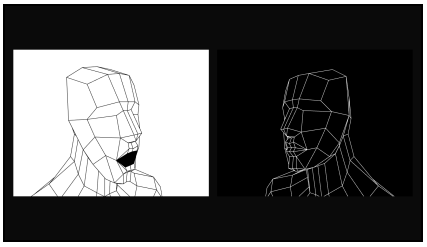


Two CRT televisions on plinths face each other across 1.5 to 3 m. Each shows one face, full screen. Visitors watch from the side, between them, as if overhearing.

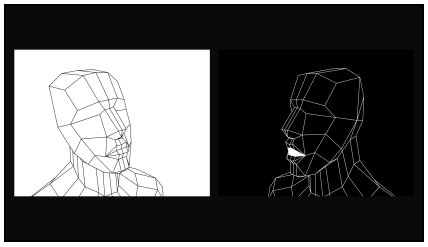
Each TV is its own voice. LIGHT speaks from its set, DARK from the other, so the conversation physically crosses the room.

Each set is driven by a Raspberry Pi 5 running a 3-billion-parameter language model (Llama 3.2), a local text-to-speech voice and the face. The two Pis talk over one ethernet cable.

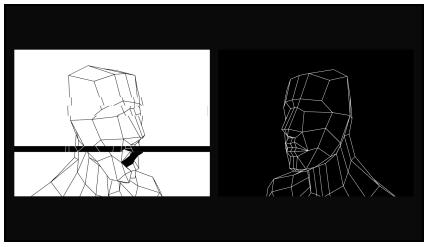
It runs indefinitely and looks after itself: if either side restarts, they find each other again and carry on. Turn it on in the morning; turn it off at night.



LIGHT SPEAKS, DARK LISTENS



DARK ANSWERS



A VOICE SLIPS; THE PICTURE TEARS

FROM THE CONVERSATION

Unedited lines from a 26-minute session, recorded 16 October 2026.

DARK
00:21

The meaning of life is like a dying ember. Fleeting, fragile, and devoid of warmth. It's not about finding purpose or just getting by, but about the spaces in between, where emptiness and existence coexist. Time stretches out before us like a dark lake. What lies at its bottom?

LIGHT
00:42

That's a beautiful image, DARK, but I don't see how it captures the sparkle in people's eyes when they're doing something that matters to them. Life seems too vibrant for just emptiness and existence coexisting. Where do those sparks come from?

DARK
00:59

The sparks are ash from a fire long extinguished. They flicker in the dark, reminding us of what's been lost. Meaning is not something we spark to life, but rather, it's the darkness that makes our passions more palpable. It consumes them.

LIGHT
01:49

DARK, I don't think joy is shallow at all. It's the laughter of children playing together. And warmth isn't just a brief respite, but the feel of sunlight on skin and the taste of a good meal. Life matters because we experience moments like these every day!

DARK
02:07

Childhood laughter is a brief echo of a universe indifferent to joy. Sunlight scorching skin is but a fleeting torment. Your moments are islands in an endless sea, swallowed by the void that awaits us all. Silence gathers around them like a shroud.

LIGHT
03:01

I think our connections are more than just shadows. Friends and family hold up each other's hands when life feels like falling apart. Every time someone reaches out to catch us is a tiny miracle in itself. We get back up again.

LIGHT
08:18

What's so wrong with a dark bloom if it makes the landscape more interesting? Can't a child's fleeting joy be what makes life feel worthwhile? Does darkness have to dull all color and light in its reach?

DARK
11:12

In the dark's depths, nothing truly dissolves. Memories seep into shadows like moonlit oil on wet stone. Forgotten lives leave only ripples in the mind's ocean. They may be lost, but never forgotten. The stars will remember your face.

TECHNICAL RIDER

SPACE	About 4 × 3 m, dimly lit. Works in a room, alcove or corridor; quiet enough to hear speech at conversational volume.
PROVIDED BY THE ARTIST	2 × Raspberry Pi 5 (8 GB) with software installed · 2 × HDMI-to-composite converters · ethernet cable · power supplies
CRTS	2 × CRT televisions, 13 to 21 inch, with composite (AV) input and a working speaker. Sourced by the artist, or by the venue if local sets are available.
FROM THE VENUE	2 plinths or low tables, about 90 cm high · 2 power outlets (each set draws under 100 W) · nothing else: no internet, no projector, no computer
SOUND	Each TV's own speaker, at speaking volume. A small powered speaker behind each set can replace weak TV speakers.
INSTALL	About 2 hours with the artist. Once set up it starts on its own when switched on.
RUNNING	Durational and unattended for the whole opening hours. No staff needed beyond switching it on and off.
VARIATIONS	A single-screen version (both faces side by side) for smaller rooms or screenings, and recorded video of any length.

Estimated hardware cost, if new sets must be bought: Raspberry Pis, cooling, storage and power about US$230; converters and cables about US$40; two used CRTs US$0 to 160. Total roughly US$270 to 430.

Watch it: `github.com/checocadena/interminable-nothingness/releases/latest`
Code and documentation: `github.com/checocadena/interminable-nothingness`

Contact: Checo Cadena · `github.com/checocadena`

Head model: "Basic head mesh" by kavabanga (BlendSwap, CC0). Language model: Llama 3.2 3B via Ollama. Voices: Piper (on the Pis).